

KDE 4.3

It's the Desktop You Need, Almost



"KDE will very shortly become the desktop you need and not the desktop we think you need," was something stated by someone from the KDE team. Looking at 4.3, we think there's a fair chance that version 4.4 actually gets there.

*W*hat do you think of when you read something like this: "Fixed over 10,000 bugs and implemented almost 2,000 feature requests in the last 6 months; close to 63,000 changes were checked in by a little under 700 contributors...?" Now, that's what I call developers being really busy working on something solid.

Guess it's time to start our journey with KDE 4.3.

The first thing you notice in this version is the brand new theme called *Air*. This replaces the default and darker *Oxygen* that's been around since the inception of the KDE4 desktop. *Air*, by contrast, is a transparent white theme with nice stripes and spirals, which make it look quite appealing. Mind you, *Oxygen* is still available, besides various other themes that can be downloaded from KDE-Look.org by accessing the **New Theme** button from the Desktop Settings tool (you get it up by right clicking on an empty space on your desktop).

While we're on the subject of Desktop Settings—this tool has also received some attention. First, you have another type of activity setting—apart from Folder View (the traditional desktop with icons), and Desktop (the default desktop containment introduced in KDE 4.1)—dubbed 'Plain Desktop'. It is basically a desktop without the toolbox you get on the top right corner to zoom-out of an activity and create new ones. Apparently, more activity types have been introduced, one of which can enable you to use your desktop screen as a whiteboard of sorts. However, I couldn't figure out a way to install these. [Let us know if you can.]

Another nice add-on under Desktop Settings is the additional wallpaper types—Virus, Mandelbrot, Weather and Globe, besides the slide show and patterns, which have been available for a while (Figure 1). Among these, I quite like the Globe add-on, which uses the Marble program to render